CBSE Class 10 Political Science Notes Chapter - 6 Political Parties

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BASIC CONCEPTS

- **Political Party**

  (i) A political party is a group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in the government.

  (ii) They agree on some policies and programmes for the society with a view to promote the collective good. Since there can be different views on what is good for all parties try to persuade people why their policies are better than others.

(iii) Parties reflect fundamental political divisions in a society. Parties are about a part of the society and thus involve PARTISANSHIP.

(iv) Thus a party is known by which part it stands for, which policies it supports and whose interests it upholds. A political party has three components:

(a) the leaders,

(b) the active members and

(c) the followers

- **Why do we need Political Parties?**

Political parties are easily one of the most visible institutions in a democracy. For most ordinary citizens, democracy is equal to political parties.

At the same time this visibility does not mean popularity. Most people tend to be very critical of political parties.

They tend to blame parties for all that is wrong with our democracy and our political life. Parties have become identified with social and political divisions.

- **Functions of a Political Party**

Parties do so by performing a series of functions:

(i) Parties contest elections.

(ii) Parties put forward different policies and programmes and the voters choose from them.

(iii) Parties play a decisive role in making laws for a country.

(iv) Parties form and run governments.

(v) Those parties that lose in the elections play the role of opposition to the parties in power, by voicing different views and criticising government for its failures or wrong policies. Opposition parties also mobilise opposition to the government.

(vi) Parties shape public opinion.

(vii) Parties provide people access to government machinery and welfare schemes implemented by governments.

- **Types of Parties**

(i) More than 750 parties are registered with the Election Commission of India. But not all these parties are serious contenders in the elections.

(ii) In some countries, only one party is allowed to control and run the government. These are called one-party systems.

(iii) In some countries, power usually changes between two main parties. Several other parties. may exist, contest elections and win a few seats in the national legislatures. But only the two main parties have a serious chance of winning majority of seats to form government. Such party system is called two-party system.

(iv) If several parties compete for power, and more than two parties have a reasonable chance of coming to power either on their own strength or in alliance with others, we call it a multiparty system.

(v) When several parties in a multi-party system join hands for the purpose of contesting elections and winning power, it is called an alliance or a front.

- **National Parties**

(i) Parties that are present in only one of the federal units and parties that are present in several or all units of the federation. This is the case in India as well. There are some countrywide parties, which are called 'national parties'.

(ii) Every party in the country has to register with the Election Commission. While the Commission treats all parties equally, it offers some special facilities to large and established parties. These parties are given a unique symbol – only the official candidates of that party can use that election symbol.

(iii) Parties that get this privilege and some other special facilities are 'recognised by the Election Commission for this purpose. That is why these parties are called, 'recognised political parties'.

(iv) The Election Commission has laid down detailed criteria of the proportion of votes and seats that a party must get in order to be a recognised party.

(v) A party that secures at least six per cent of the total votes in an election to the Legislative Assembly of a State and wins at least two seats is recognised as a State party.

(vi) A party that secures at least six per cent of the total votes in Lok Sabha elections or Assembly elections in four States and wins at least four seats in the Lok Sabha is recognised as a national party

- **Challenges to Political Parties**

(i) The first challenge is lack of internal democracy within parties.

(ii) The second challenge of dynastic succession is related to the first one.

(iii) The third challenge is about the growing role of money and muscle power in parties, especially during elections.

- **How can Parties be Reformed?**

In a democracy, the final decision is made by leaders who represent political parties. People can replace them, but only by another set of party leaders.

Some of the recent efforts and suggestions in our country to reform political parties and its leader:

(i) The Constitution was amended to prevent elected MLAs and MPs from changing parties. This was done because many elected representatives were indulging in DEFECTION in order to become ministers or for cash rewards

(ii) The Supreme Court passed an order to reduce the influence of money and criminals. Now, it is mandatory for every candidate who contests electione ta file an ACCIDAVIT giving details of his/her property and criminal cases pending against him.

(iii) The Election Commission passed an order making it necessary for political parties to hold their organisational elections and file their income tax returns.

(iv) A law should be made to regulate the internal affairs of political parties. It should be made compulsory for political parties to maintain a register of its members, to follow its own constitution, to have an independent authority, to act as a judge in case of party disputes, to hold open elections to the highest posts.

(v) It should be made mandatory for political parties to give a minimum number of tickets, about one-third, to women candidates.

(vi) There should be state funding of elections. The government should give parties money to support their election expenses. This support could be given in kind: petrol, paper, telephone etc. Or it could be given in cash on the basis of the votes secured by the party in the last election

IMPORTANT TERMS

- Partisanship is a tendency to support a particular group, cause or viewpoint over another.
- Election: An election is a process in which people vote to choose a person or group of people to hold an official position.

- Ruling Party: A party that is in power in a given country, usually through a majority in parliament, or as part of the ruling coalition.
- Opposition Party: The opposition comprises of one or more political parties or other organized groups that are opposed to the government party. It is the party that goes against the ruling party
- Election Commission is a body incharge for overseeing the implementation of **election** procedures.
- Two-party System is a party system where two major political parties dominate the government. One of the two parties typically holds a majority in the legislature and is usually referred to as the majority or governing party while the other is the minority or opposition party.
- Communism: A theory or system of social organisation in which all property is owned by the community and each person contributes and receives according to their ability and needs.
- Communist: A person who supports or believes in the principles of communism.
- Multi-party System is a **system**in which multiple political **parties** across the political spectrum run for national election, and all have the capacity to gain control of government offices, separately or in coalition.
- Alliance: A union or association formed for mutual benefit, especially between countries organisations.
- Federal: Having or relating to a system of government in which power is shared between a central government and individual states.
- Federalism: The federal principle or system of government in which power is shared between Central authority an the constituent units (states).
- Legislative Assembly is the name given in some countries to either a legislature, or to one of its organs of the government.
- Lok Sabha (House of the People) is the Lower house of India's bicameral Parliament in which representatives are directly elected by the people with the Upper house being the Rajya **Sabha**. Membership of Lok shabha is 550 (maximum) and the present strength is 545.
- Rajya Sabha: Council of States is the upper house of the Parliament of India. Membership of **Rajya Sabha** is limited by the Constitution to a maximum of 250 members, and current law have provision for 245 members.

- Marxism: **Marxism** is a the theory of Karl Marx which says that society's classes are the cause of struggle and the society should have no classes.
- Internal Democracy also known as intra-party **democracy**, refers to the level and methods of including party members in the decision making and deliberation within the party structure.
- Defection: Its is changing party allegiance from the political party from which a person got elected to a different party
- Affidavit: A written statement confirmed by oath or affirmation, for use as evidence in court

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